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Calif. Gov. Newsom: California is Best State for Families

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SACRAMENTO, California, Oct. 17 -- Gov. Gavin Newsom, D-California, issued the following news release on Oct. 16, 2024:

Governor Gavin Newsom and First Partner Jennifer Siebel Newsom celebrated the passage and recent signing of several pieces of legislation to support women, children, and families, just as national Republican leaders continue to block policies to support them. The package of bills the Legislature sent to the Governor includes new laws to support victims of revenge porn, protect kids from social media addiction and limit smartphone use distractions in classrooms, address gender-based violence, and expand access to healthier foods in schools. These bills demonstrate the ongoing work of the Newsom administration and the Legislature to ensure that California is the best state to raise a family.

"While leaders in Republican-led states go to work every day to make life harder for families in their states, from the classroom to the courtroom, we will keep fighting to make sure California is the best place in the nation to grow up and raise a family."

- Governor Gavin Newsom

"In California, we are committed to building a future where every child gets the best start in life, and every woman has the opportunity to thrive. Through California for ALL Kids and California for ALL Women, we are working to protect children, support families, and empower women. From safeguarding children's mental health to advancing maternal care and combating gender based violence, these new laws reflect our unwavering dedication to creating a state where everyone has the resources and opportunity to live with dignity."

- First Partner Jennifer Siebel Newsom

Putting money in families' pockets

California has its own California Earned Income Tax Credit (CalEITC), which last year provided nearly 3.5 million California filers additional resources to make ends meet and provide for their families. California also added the Young Child Tax Credit and Foster Youth Tax Credit. These tax credits are inclusive of all Californians who file their taxes including immigrant families who pay their taxes with an IRS-provided Taxpayer Identification Number but are ineligible for most federal tax benefits.

Governor Newsom also launched the country's largest college savings program, known as the CalKIDS program, which invests $1.9 billion into accounts for low-income school-age children in grades 1-12 and for newborn children born on or after July 1, 2022. All families of low-income public school students - 3.4 million across the state - can access college savings accounts created in their children's names, with seed investments of between $500 and $1,500.

The administration has also boosted paid leave benefits for lower- and middle-income employees to cover more of their regular income while they take much-needed time off to care for loved ones, including by increasing wage replacement rates for State Disability Insurance and Paid Family Leave beginning in 2025, and enabling workers to take paid sick leave or family leave in order to care for a person designated by the employee.

Administration efforts to support healthy kids

California standards already exceed federal rules for food safety in schools, ensuring children are consuming fewer amounts of added sugars, sodium, and more fruits, vegetables, and whole grains. Governor Newsom established first-in-the-nation state funding for universal school meals for all public school children in California and from that program, First Partner Jennifer Siebel Newsom championed efforts to develop the innovative California Farm to School initiative. California also participates in the federal SUN Bucks food program, unlike 13 Republican-led states, which ensures that children in families with low incomes have adequate nutrition while school is out for the summer.

California's leadership on reproductive rights

In the over two years since the U.S. Supreme Court overturned Roe v. Wade, Governor Newsom, in partnership with the California Legislature, has built California into a national leader for reproductive freedom. Governor Newsom is a founding member of the Reproductive Freedom Alliance, a nonpartisan coalition of 23 Governors committed to protecting and expanding reproductive freedom. The Newsom administration has invested more than $240 million to protect and expand access to reproductive health care in California since the reversal of Roe. Last month, he signed SB 729 by Senator Caroline Menjivar (D-Van Nuys) to require large group health care service plan contracts and disability insurance policies to provide coverage for the diagnosis and treatment of infertility and fertility service, including in vitro fertilization (IVF). California also has one of the lowest maternal mortality rates in the country and the Surgeon General recently unveiled a new initiative - Strong Start & Beyond - to bring that number down further.

New legislation to protect women

* AB 1936 by Assemblymember Sabrina Cervantes (D-Riverside) - Maternal mental health screenings.

* AB 2020 by Assemblymember Mia Bonta (D-Oakland) - Survivors of Human Trafficking Support Act.

* AB 2319 by Assemblymember Lori Wilson (D-Suisun City) - California Dignity in Pregnancy and Childbirth Act.

* AB 2515 by Assemblymember Diane Papan (D-San Mateo) - Menstrual products: perfluoroalkyl and polyfluoroalkyl substances (PFAS).

* AB 2740 by Assemblymember Marie Waldron (R - San Diego) - Incarcerated persons: prenatal and postpartum care.

* AB 2843 by Assemblymember Cottie Petrie-Norris (D-Irvine) - Health care coverage: rape and sexual assault.

* SB 926 by Dr. Aisha Wahab, Senator (D-Hayward) - Crimes: distribution of intimate images.

* SB 981 by Dr. Aisha Wahab, Senator (D-Hayward) - Sexually explicit digital images.

* SB 1386 by Senator Anna Caballero (D-Merced) - Evidence: sexual assault.

New legislation to support kids

* AB 438 by Assemblymember Blanca Rubio (D-Baldwin Park) - Pupils with exceptional needs: individualized education programs: postsecondary goals and transition services.

* AB 1282 by Assemblymember Josh Lowenthal (D-Long Beach) - Mental health: impacts of social media.

* AB 1831 by Assemblymember Marc Berman (D-Menlo Park) - Crimes: child pornography.

* AB 1913 by Assemblymember Dawn Addis (D-Morro Bay) - Pupil safety: child abuse prevention: training.

* AB 2229 by Assemblymember Lori Wilson (D-Suisun City) - California Healthy Youth Act: menstrual health education.

* AB 2316 by Assemblymember Jesse Gabriel (D-Encino) - Pupil nutrition: substances: prohibition.

* AB 2317 by Assemblymember Stephanie Nguyen (D-Elk Grove)- Child day care facilities: anaphylactic policy.

* AB 3216 by Assemblymember Josh Hoover (R-Folsom) - Pupils: use of smartphones.

* SB 939 by Senator Thomas Umberg (D- Santa Ana) - Education equity: schoolsite and community resources: neurodivergent pupils.

* SB 976 by Senator Nancy Skinner (D-Berkeley) - Protecting Our Kids from Social Media Addiction Act.

* SB 1043 by Senator Shannon Grove (R-Bakersfield) - Short-term residential therapeutic programs: dashboard: seclusion or behavioral restraints.

* SB 1063 by Senator Shannon Grove (R-Bakersfield) - Pupil safety: identification cards.

* SB 1248 by Melissa Hurtado (D-Bakersfield) - Pupil health: extreme weather conditions: physical activity.

* SB 1283 by Senator Henry Stern (D-Los Angeles) - Pupils: use of social media.

* SB 1381 by Senator Aisha Wahab (D-Silicon Valley) - Crimes: child pornography.

* SB 1414 by Senator Shannon Grove (R-Bakersfield) - Crimes: solicitation of a minor.

New legislation to build strong families

* AB 51 by Assemblymember Mia Bonta (D-Oakland) - Early childcare and education: California state preschool program.

* SB 729 by Senator Caroline Menjivar (D-Van Nuys) - Health care coverage: treatment for infertility and fertility services.

* SB 1197 by Senator Marie Alvarado-Gil (D-Jackson) - In-home respite services.

* SB 1300 by Senator Dave Cortese (D-San Jose) - Health facility closure: public notice: inpatient psychiatric and perinatal services.

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Original text here: https://www.gov.ca.gov/2024/10/16/california-is-the-best-state-for-families-heres-why/

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